Atomic Red Team and APT29 analysis

Weeks 9 and 10 project report

Introduction to Threat Hunting | Academic year 2026–2027

Group project: Forensic Analysis and Detection of Simulated Infostealer-Like Activity in Windows Environments

Revised 12 November 2026 | Practice instructor: Noyan Tendikov

Results and scope

The revised Linux experiment ran three Atomic Red Team procedures and six controls. Elasticsearch indexed 29 executions. Of 11 tar/gzip events, the old argument filter selected five and the revised query selected three. All nine scenarios returned their expected counts with each query.

Ten APT29 techniques are mapped to ATT&CK. The Windows analysis connects the group's archived PowerShell record and process inventory to local file staging. Published incident evidence explains how investigators established a Chrome password export and investigated cookie theft.

Syllabus requirement	Delivered evidence
Week 9 selected Atomic tests	Three pinned tests, native traces, outcome checks and cleanup
Week 9 SIEM analysis	Actual Elasticsearch queries, responses and isolated control fixtures
Week 10 APT29 or APT41 analysis	APT29 source analysis, ten mappings and a Navigator layer
Transparent increments and defense	Separate commits with real dates; a 7 minute 30 second defense outline

This report accompanies the complete Markdown documentation, scripts and machine-readable evidence in the GitHub repository. The group must perform the oral defense; no teacher evaluation or successful defense is claimed.

GitHub project and evidence

Week 9 laboratory design

The available computer runs Linux. The experiment therefore uses official Linux atomics as a portable extension of the Windows-focused project. It does not reproduce the entire Week 8 adversary-emulation chain. Execution and archiving were selected because both fit the project and can be exercised using synthetic files without access to real credentials.

Technique and test	GUID	Action
T1059.004 test 8	b04ed73c-7d43-4dc8-b563-a2fc595cba1a	Shell loop prints five markers
T1560.001 test 6	cde3c2af-3485-49eb-9c1f-0ed60e9cc0af	gzip compresses mock-browser.json
T1560.001 test 7	7af2b51e-ad1c-498c-aca8-d3290c19535a	tar archives the lab-browser folder

The commands were executed manually through the documented executor model, with a custom strace wrapper. Invoke-AtomicRedTeam was not used. Test numbers are recorded at source commit a0e3f9bc69fed2fd711bd1f1aa87a40c33482fe6; GUIDs and YAML file hashes make the selection traceable even if upstream ordering changes.

All inputs are generated training data. The folder contains a fake browser credential record and an invalid session token. The gzip output remains present until after the tar test, so the tar member list also contains that earlier compressed file. No browser profile, DPAPI store, valid token, external receiver or persistence mechanism is involved.

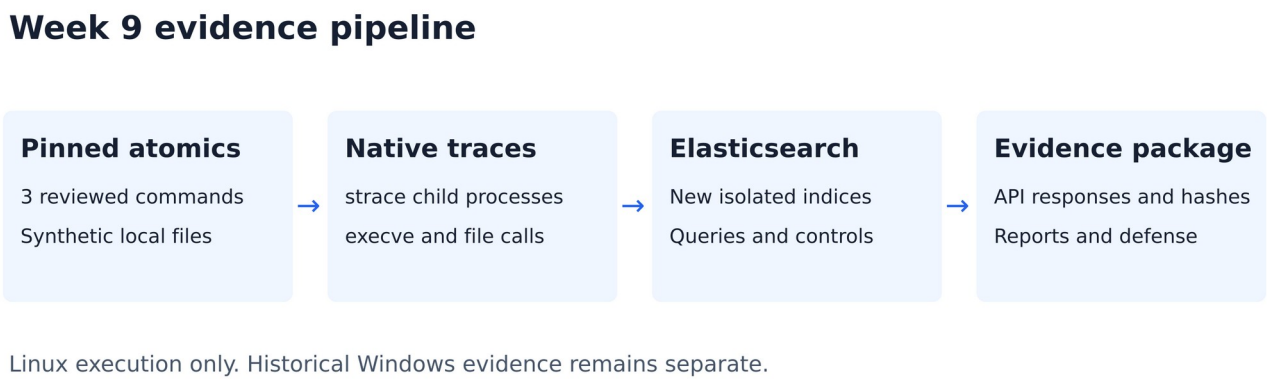


Figure 1. Evidence collection and analysis workflow. Original diagram, not a tool screenshot.

The collector traces only its child processes. The resulting events are labelled lab.strace and host.name is the fixed pseudonym LAB-LINUX. They are not Sysmon, Windows Security events or system-wide endpoint telemetry.

Original execution evidence from 8 November

Case	Exit code	execve events	Outcome
atomic_shell	0	7	Verified markers
atomic_gzip	0	2	Verified archive
atomic_tar	0	4	Verified archive
benign_backup	0	4	Benign control
plain_control	0	1	Benign control

The raw strace files preserve successful execve calls and file operations. Each normalized event records the originating trace filename and line number. Failed PATH lookups are excluded. Five parser/provenance tests cover successful launches, failed lookups, file-only calls, escaped arguments and reconstruction of every archived event.

The shell test produced all five expected marker lines. Decompressing the gzip file reproduced the exact mock-browser bytes. Reading the expected tar members reproduced the source browser and cookie files. SHA-256 values were saved before the generated archives were removed by cleanup. Synthetic inputs, output streams, traces and outcome records remain in the evidence directory.

Collection interval: 8 November 2026, 14:59:56–15:00:01 UTC, equivalent to 19:59:56–20:00:01 in Asia/Almaty. These are actual execution times, not assigned week dates.

Run ID: 20261108T145956001720Z

Reproducible commands

```
python3 scripts/collect_week9_atomics.py
```

```
python3 scripts/analyze_week9_elastic.py evidence/week9/<NEW_RUN_ID>
```

```
python3 -m unittest discover -s tests -v
```

Start the dedicated Elasticsearch instance first using config/week9-elasticsearch.yml. The full Markdown runbook gives the verified archive version, loopback ports, Kibana data-view setup and preservation rules. Each new collection has a unique directory and index; the analyzer refuses to overwrite an existing run.

Published source hashes permit byte-integrity checks. They establish consistency of the retained artifacts, not independent certification of the lab or production detection accuracy.

Original SIEM results from 8 November

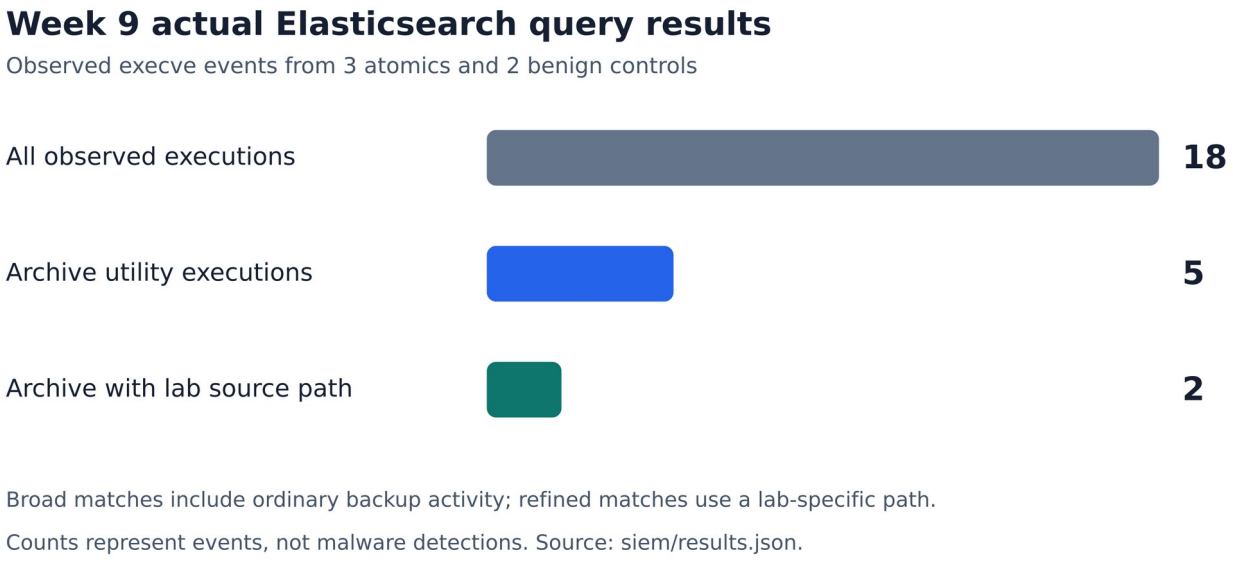


Figure 2. Counts calculated from the saved Elasticsearch responses.

The broad query selects process.name equal to tar or gzip within lab.strace. It excludes shell wrapper events even when their command strings mention an archiver. The refined query additionally requires an argument containing lab-browser. Neither query selects on case labels, expected outcomes or Atomic test IDs.

In the original five-case run, the refined query selected the two actual profile archives. The expanded experiment on the next page tests whether this interpretation holds when the marker appears only in the output name or a listing command.

The original search matched a substring anywhere in the argument list. The revised search uses the requested operation and a successful file open by the same process.

Validation	Result
Collection versus ingestion count	Matched
Expected refined cases	atomic_gzip and atomic_tar
Separate boundary fixtures	10 synthetic documents; 20 assertions passed
Archive integrity and cleanup	Passed

Elasticsearch and Kibana run as a separate loopback-only teaching instance. This increment implements custom collection and hunting in Elastic; it does not configure an Elastic Security integration or scheduled alerts. Use the archived UTC time range when demonstrating the observations.

Corrected archive query and live controls

12 November 2026, Asia/Almaty. The same 29 process events were searched with both queries. Eleven launched tar or gzip. The old path predicate matched five events. The revised query matched three.

Executed case	Original / revised	Why the result matters
Atomic gzip / tar	1 / 1 each	Both processes opened registered profile inputs.
Ordinary backup	0 / 0	Unrelated cookies.json has different bytes.
Marker in output name	1 / 0	Only ordinary documents went into the backup.
List that archive	1 / 0	tar -tf listed existing members.
Renamed profile	0 / 1	A legitimate archive of known profile copies matched.
Decompress only	1 / 0	gzip -dc wrote to stdout.
Shell / plain control	0 / 0 each	Neither case launched an archiver.

How to verify a match

The collector inventories paths whose bytes match the synthetic profile before execution. For supported tar/gzip create commands, the analyzer examines subsequent read-only opens in the same PID up to its next successful exec. strace -y resolves each returned descriptor; the published lab root is /lab. Elasticsearch requires a create mode and a supporting open line.

The renamed-profile tar trace records both input opens at lines 12–13. The control verifies behavior even when the folder name changes. A permitted backup can still match. Unknown inputs, unsupported flag combinations and missing file-open telemetry reduce coverage.

Nine control outcomes and counts in Elasticsearch

Input opens in the renamed-profile trace

Week 10 APT29 case analysis

APT29 is the selected group. MITRE identifies it as G0016 and links it to Russia's SVR. SolarWinds is the main case; the later StellarParticle investigations are identified separately. Attribution is reported intelligence, not a conclusion drawn from our local test results. [1, 2]

FireEye's December 2020 report describes SUNBURST delivery through compromised SolarWinds Orion updates. Its May 2022 attribution update associates the original UNC2452 activity with APT29. The investigation also reports temporary scheduled-task modifications followed by restoration. [3]

Microsoft's January 2021 investigation describes archiving with 7-Zip, including password-protected and split archives. This is the direct behavioral bridge to our tar/gzip exercise, while the operating system, utility and additional options differ. [4]

CrowdStrike's January 2022 StellarParticle report includes investigations extending into 2021. It reports Chrome profile and DPAPI material being accessed for cookies, as well as evidence of saved-password export. These observations are relevant to infostealers but must not be collapsed into a universal sequence for every Orion compromise. [5]

APT29 selected techniques and project evidence

Source-backed CTI is separate from laboratory validation

ATT&CK	Technique	Project evidence
T1195.002	Compromise Software Supply Chain	CTI only / not validated
T1059.001	PowerShell	Historical Windows lab
T1059.003	Windows Command Shell	CTI only / not validated
T1053.005	Scheduled Task	CTI only / not validated
T1555.003	Credentials from Web Browsers	CTI only / not validated
T1539	Steal Web Session Cookie	CTI only / not validated
T1005	Data from Local System	CTI only / not validated
T1560.001	Archive via Utility	Linux archive analogue
T1074.002	Remote Data Staging	CTI only / not validated
T1048.002	Asymmetric encrypted non-C2 exfiltration	CTI only / not validated

ATT&CK v20.1 checked 8 Nov 2026. Colors are evidence labels, not detection scores.

Figure 3. Ten selected mappings. Evidence categories are not coverage scores.

ATT&CK v20.1 was current on 8 November 2026. The Navigator layer identifies major version 20 and retains evidence-status comments. Its colors distinguish CTI-only items, historical Windows work and the newly executed Linux archive analogue. [6]

Week 10 mapping and hunt priorities

ATT&CK	Observed behavior in sources	Project implication
T1195.002	Trojanized software updates [3]	Delivery context only
T1059.001 / .003	PowerShell and cmd activity [2]	Earlier Windows evidence stays historical
T1053.005	Temporary task modification [3]	Collect task changes in a future VM run
T1555.003	Saved browser-password export [5]	Mock JSON does not test credential access
T1539	Browser cookie theft [5]	Fake cookies do not prove session theft
T1005	File collection [2]	Add suitable file-read telemetry
T1560.001	7-Zip archive creation [4]	Linux tar/gzip analogue only
T1074.002	Archives on an OWA server [2]	Local output is not remote staging
T1048.002	HTTPS retrieval of staged data [2]	No transfer executed in this lab

The machine-readable mapping lists each technique’s current tactics, source URL, evidence status and proposed hunt. The table is a selected subset rather than the complete APT29 catalogue. A tactic association does not establish every tactical use in the cited incident.

Next experiment

Use a dedicated Windows VM and synthetic browser-profile inputs. Collect process creation and file-access telemetry from sensors that actually provide those events. Correlate access to the synthetic files with an archive operation, then compare with a normal backup. Add controlled transfer and identity telemetry only as separate experiments with their own evidence.

Process creation and file-created events alone do not demonstrate file reads. A local archive does not establish exfiltration. A plaintext mock record does not test browser credential decryption. The Unix shell test is T1059.004 and is not relabelled PowerShell or attributed to APT29.

Transparency and defense

The two original increments were committed on 8 November. The 12 November revision adds control evidence and a Windows artifact review. The defense guide allocates 7 minutes 30 seconds. The group still needs to present the findings to its instructor.

Windows evidence for execution and browser access

Local PowerShell execution on 22 October

Event 400 record 28101 identifies PID 12292 and engine startup at 11:17:22.8355311 UTC. A CIM sample at 11:17:22.9908514 UTC identifies powershell.exe and its parent pwsh.exe (PID 2732). A run-specific stdout marker and identical SHA-256 values for the source and staged mock files corroborate the local copy. File access and identity activity require separate sensors.

Group evidence: native PowerShell event

Published StellarParticle investigation

T1555.003. RDP Bitmap Cache reconstruction displayed Chrome exporting saved passwords to a plaintext CSV. This supports an export in the observed session. Further evidence would be needed to determine subsequent use of that file.

T1539. Shellbags documented navigation through Chrome and DPAPI directories. A Falcon NewScriptWritten event identified the Cookie Editor extension. The investigators correlated these artifacts with session impersonation and assessed offline decryption as likely. Directory navigation alone cannot establish a copy or successful reuse.

CrowdStrike investigation, figures 2–4

Windows validation for a future VM run

Enable successful Audit File System and a matching SACL on synthetic files. Find Security 4663 events with ReadData (access-mask bit 0x1). Join object path, host, time and process ID with 4688 NewProcessId from the process lifetime. Enable command-line auditing. Repeat creation, listing and ordinary backup controls. The group’s archived evidence supplies Event 400 and CIM for the earlier run.

Microsoft documentation for file access auditing (4663)

Microsoft documentation for process creation (4688)

Sources and deliverable guide

[1] MITRE ATT&CK APT29 group G0016

Live profile checked 2026-11-08. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[2] MITRE ATT&CK SolarWinds Compromise C0024

Live profile checked 2026-11-08. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[3] FireEye Mandiant SolarWinds supply chain investigation

2020-12-13; attribution update May 2022. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[4] Microsoft Solorigate second-stage investigation

2021-01-20. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[5] CrowdStrike Observations from the StellarParticle Campaign

2022-01-27; includes investigations extending into 2021. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[6] MITRE ATT&CK version history

v20.1 current when checked 2026-11-08. Accessed 8 November 2026.

[7] Atomic Red Team pinned source

[8] Syllabus 2026–2027 section 3.3

The syllabus file was read locally and checked against the authenticated LMS folder. Only a paraphrase of the relevant requirements is included; the course document is not republished.

Repository material	Purpose
docs/week9-atomic-red-team.md	Practical report and full reproduction guide
docs/week10-apt29-analysis.md	Source-qualified analysis and links
docs/weeks9-10-defense.md	Timed script and rehearsal questions
evidence/week9/<RUN_ID>/	Native traces, collection checks and SIEM evidence
data/week9/ and data/week10/	Pinned tests, source register and ATT&CK mapping

AI assistance: OpenAI Codex assisted with research, mapping, code, lab execution, verification and writing. The group should review and understand the work and follow the instructor’s AI-permission and disclosure requirements. This document does not assert that instructor permission was granted.